CNN 10/16/2026

Trump ally removed from role after report of State Department feud

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Updated: 6:40 PM EDT, Thu October 15, 2026

Source: CNN

A political appointee with deep ties to the Trump family has been removed from his special envoy role following a report of a feud with a top State Department official.

Paolo Zampolli, who served as US special envoy for global partnerships, “was notified today that his status as an envoy has been terminated and he is no longer a government employee,” a US official said Thursday. Two other officials confirmed he’d been removed.

The news of his termination comes hours after a Politico report detailing a monthslong dispute between Zampolli and Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau. According to the report, the feud played out over email on a widespread number of topics, particularly related to chain of command, and messages between the two included personal attacks.

Zampolli is the second Trump administration diplomat who had personal ties to President Donald Trump to be ousted from the administration in recent days, following the forced resignation of Kimberly Guilfoyle who had served as the US ambassador to Greece.

Zampolli, a businessman and former modeling agent, represented Melania Trump. He hosted a party in 1998 where he said he introduced Melania Trump to her would-be husband.

In a statement Thursday, Zampolli noted that his special envoy role, which was only supposed to last a year, had already been extended by Trump for six months.

“Years ago, (Trump) told me I was too good for modeling and brought me into real estate,” he said. “Now he told me: ‘Why do you want to work in government when you can close all these deals?’”

“The President is always right,” Zampolli said, adding that “serving him and the United States has been the greatest honor of my life.”

“I am deeply grateful to President Trump, Vice President (JD) Vance, Secretary (Marco) Rubio and the entire team,” he said. “Now it is time for the next chapter - back to business, building relationships and closing deals.”

“President Trump changed my life once. He just did it again,” Zampolli said.

Trump announced Zampolli as special envoy for global partnerships in March 2025.

“With his extensive experience working with the United Nations, the Kennedy Center, and various International initiatives, Paolo will help us advance America’s Interests on the Global stage,” Trump wrote on Truth Social at the time.

Zampolli served on the Board of the Kennedy Center during Trump’s first term and was also an ambassador to the UN for the Caribbean island of Dominica.

Zampolli touted securing business deals for the administration while serving as special envoy.

He stirred controversy earlier this year related to the World Cup when he suggested Italy, where he was born, could play in the place of Iran. He told CNN at the time that he believed Iran was no longer participating amid the war with the US. Italy had failed to qualify.

“A World Cup without Messi is not a World Cup,” Zampolli said. “Italy has the same merits after winning four times the World Cup.”

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